

BULLYING & HARASSMENT POLICY

1. Purpose and Commitment

Sporting Chance Project Ltd (SCP) is committed to providing a safe, inclusive, and supportive environment for all children, young people, staff, and volunteers. Bullying and harassment in any form are unacceptable and will not be tolerated. This policy outlines SCP's commitment to preventing, identifying, and responding to bullying and harassment promptly, fairly, and effectively.

SCP recognises that bullying and harassment, including racism and faith-targeted abuse, can significantly affect a child or young person's welfare, sense of safety, emotional wellbeing, mental health, attendance, engagement, and educational outcomes. In line with Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026 and Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026, SCP adopts a zero-tolerance, child-centred, and safeguarding-led approach.

This policy reflects Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026, effective from 1 September 2026, including its expanded expectations for child-on-child abuse involving harassment and violence. It should also be read with the Equality Act 2010, the Human Rights Act 1998, Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 and relevant local safeguarding partnership procedures.

SCP operates across Bristol City Council, South Gloucestershire Council, and Bath & North East Somerset (BANES), and follows the safeguarding procedures and referral pathways of the relevant Local Authority

2. Definitions

Bullying is behaviour by an individual or group, usually repeated over time, that intentionally hurts, intimidates or harms another person or group. A single serious incident may still constitute harassment, abuse or another safeguarding concern and must not be disregarded merely because it has not been repeated. Bullying can include:

- Physical: Hitting, pushing, damaging belongings
- Verbal: Name-calling, teasing, threats
- Emotional or psychological: Exclusion, spreading rumours, manipulation
- Online or digital: Cyberbullying through social media, messaging, group chats, gaming, image-sharing or other platforms, including manipulated or AI-generated content

Harassment is any unwanted conduct that violates a person's dignity or creates an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating, or offensive environment. Harassment can be:

- Prejudice-based or discriminatory: Related to race, sex, disability, religion or belief, sexual orientation, gender reassignment, pregnancy or maternity, or age where legally applicable, including racist, sexist, homophobic, biphobic, transphobic, disablist or faith-based abuse
- Sexual: Unwanted conduct of a sexual nature, including sexual comments, jokes, gestures, physical contact, sexualised bullying, misogyny or misandry, online harassment, and consensual or non-consensual making or sharing of nude or semi-nude images, including images generated or manipulated using AI
- Psychological: Intimidation, belittling, or patronising behaviour

SCP recognises that bullying and harassment may:

- Occur face-to-face, online, or through digital platforms
- Be one-off or sustained over time
- Be child-on-child (peer-on-peer) or involve adults
- Form part of wider safeguarding concerns, including exploitation or abuse

Bullying and harassment may involve an imbalance of power arising from age, status, popularity, numbers, communication needs, disability, access to technology or possession of personal information or images. SCP will remain alert to barriers that may make it harder for children with SEND or communication needs to recognise, report or explain abuse.

3. Prevention Strategies

SCP promotes an inclusive, anti-discriminatory culture of respect and zero tolerance for bullying or harassment through:

- Education & Awareness: Delivering regular training to staff, volunteers, and participants on recognising and addressing bullying and harassment.
- Open Communication: Encouraging all individuals to report concerns, with assurance that they will be supported and treated with respect.
- Supervision: Maintaining adequate staff presence during activities to monitor behaviour and reduce opportunities for inappropriate conduct.
- Positive Role Modelling: Requiring all adults involved with SCP to model respectful, inclusive behaviour.
- Clear Behaviour Expectations: Sharing SCP's behaviour expectations with participants and applying the Staff Code of Conduct contained within the SCP Child Protection & Safeguarding Policy to all staff and mentors.

In addition, SCP will:

- Promote anti-bullying messages and inclusive values across all provision
- Ensure children understand how to report concerns safely
- Recognise that vulnerable learners (e.g. SEND, SEMH, EHCP) may be at increased risk
- Embed safeguarding awareness across all learning and mentoring activity

Maintain an attitude that bullying, harassment or abuse could happen here, recognising that an absence of reports does not mean it is not occurring. Staff will recognise racism, faith-based prejudice and other discrimination as harm in its own right, and challenge inappropriate language and conduct early, including sexist or misogynistic behaviour, rather than dismissing it as banter, joking, part of growing up or boys being boys.

4. Reporting and Responding

SCP takes all reports of bullying or harassment seriously.

- Reporting: Any child, young person, parent/carer, staff member or volunteer can report an incident to any SCP team member or directly to the Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL) or Deputy DSL. Reporting arrangements will be well promoted, easy to understand and accessible to children with different ages, needs and communication methods. Staff must act on concerns even where a child does not make a formal report.
- Confidentiality: Reports will be handled sensitively and shared only with those who need the information to safeguard those involved. Staff must not promise confidentiality and must explain, in an age-appropriate way, what information may need to be shared.
- Response: SCP will take prompt, impartial and proportionate action, considering the wishes and welfare of the child reporting, the needs of all children involved and the risk to others. Staff will not investigate a possible crime or significant-harm concern beyond establishing the basic facts needed for immediate safeguarding; the DSL or Deputy DSL will consult children's social care and/or police where appropriate so SCP action does not prejudice an external investigation.
- Outcomes & Actions: Where bullying or harassment is confirmed, responses may include:
 - Informal resolution or mediation
 - Restorative practice
 - Targeted education or behaviour agreements
 - Proportionate consequences or changes to provision, agreed with the commissioning school or local authority where applicable; SCP will not use an informal exclusion

SCP will also ensure that:

- All concerns are recorded accurately and promptly
- Incidents are reviewed through a safeguarding lens
- Patterns or repeated concerns are identified and escalated
- Decisions, actions and the reasons for them are recorded; a risk and needs assessment is completed where required, particularly for sexual harassment, violence, serious physical harm or threats involving a weapon.

5. Support for Victims

SCP will ensure support for individuals affected by bullying or harassment:

- Access to trusted adults or mentors
- Emotional support or counselling
- Help with rebuilding peer relationships
- Ongoing monitoring to ensure wellbeing

Where appropriate, families or carers will be included in support planning.

SCP will also consider appropriate support and intervention for the alleged perpetrator and for witnesses or other affected children. Safeguarding the victim and providing support to an alleged perpetrator are not mutually exclusive, and any action will avoid placing responsibility on the victim or creating unnecessary disruption to their education or support. SCP recognises that victims may:

- Feel unable or unwilling to report concerns
- Experience shame, fear, or anxiety
- Require longer-term support and monitoring

All support will be child-centred, proportionate, and responsive to individual need.

6. Anti-Retaliation

SCP prohibits retaliation against anyone who reports bullying or harassment or supports an investigation. Any retaliatory action will be treated as a serious breach of policy. Retaliation will be managed as a disciplinary and safeguarding concern, and may result in escalation under SCP's safeguarding or behaviour procedures.

7. Child-on-Child Abuse (Including Harassment and Violence)

SCP recognises that some incidents of bullying or harassment, including discriminatory behaviour such as racism or faith-targeted abuse, may constitute child-on-child abuse. This is a safeguarding issue for both the victim and alleged perpetrator and is preventable through early recognition, challenge and timely, evidence-based support. Forms include:

- Sexual harassment or violence
- Initiation-type violence (hazing)
- Abuse within intimate personal relationships between children
- Physical assault, serious physical harm, or threats of harm involving a weapon
- Online abuse, upskirting, coercive or controlling behaviour, and making or sharing nude or semi-nude images, including AI-generated or manipulated images

Such cases are safeguarding matters and will be managed under the SCP Child Protection & Safeguarding Policy and Child-on-child Abuse Policy, with referral to children's social care, police or other agencies where required.

In line with Keeping Children Safe in Education 2026, SCP recognises that:

- Child-on-child abuse can occur inside or outside the setting and online
- Children can be victims, alleged perpetrators, witnesses or otherwise affected; all may require safeguarding support
- All incidents must be taken seriously and never dismissed as banter or part of growing up

8. Safeguarding Considerations

Bullying and harassment may indicate underlying safeguarding concerns. SCP will consider whether incidents are linked to:

- Abuse or neglect
- Sexual exploitation or criminal exploitation
- Domestic abuse exposure
- Mental health concerns
- Online harm or coercion
- Discrimination, hate incidents, or radicalisation

Where safeguarding concerns are identified:

- Report immediately to the Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL), or Deputy DSL in their absence, in line with SCP Child Protection & Safeguarding procedures
- Appropriate referrals will be made to external agencies where required
- The child's welfare will remain the paramount consideration

Where a concern involves an adult working with children, it will be managed under SCP's allegations, low-level concerns and LADO procedures rather than investigated solely as a bullying complaint

9. Monitoring and Oversight

SCP will monitor incidents of bullying and harassment to:

- Identify patterns, trends, or emerging risks
- Inform preventative strategies and staff training
- Ensure appropriate and consistent responses

The DSL and Senior Leadership Team will:

- Review incidents regularly
- Ensure policy compliance
- Take action where systemic issues are identified

10. Related Policies and Documents

This policy should be read alongside:

- SCP Child Protection & Safeguarding Policy (including the Staff Code of Conduct)
- Child-on-child Abuse Policy
- Whistleblowing Policy
- Complaints & Feedback Policy
- Online Safety Policy
- Equality & Diversity Policy
- Behaviour Management Policy

Approval and document control

This policy is approved by the Director of SCP and is subject to annual review or earlier review in response to changes in legislation, statutory guidance, organisational structure or safeguarding practice.

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